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POLITICAL SCIENCE DEPARTMENT
4289 BUNCHE HALL
BOX 951472
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1472

PHONE: (310) 825-4331
FAX: (310) 825-0778

January 23, 2026

To the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Selection Committee,

I am writing in strong support of **Elayne Stecher**'s nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I have supervised Elayne in her role as instructor for PS169 (*The Politics of Violent Conflict*, Summer 2024) and PS50 (*Introduction to Comparative Politics*, Summer 2025), and will again supervise her upcoming PS50 appointment (Summer 2026). In this capacity, I have had the direct and sustained opportunity to observe her course design, instructional decisions, and engagement with students. Based on this experience, I can say without hesitation that Elayne exemplifies the qualities this award is intended to recognize.

As an instructor, Elayne demonstrates exceptional pedagogical maturity and intentionality. She designs courses that prioritize analytical skill development over rote learning, and she is especially effective at teaching students how to evaluate evidence, construct arguments, and engage thoughtfully with disagreement. In both PS169 and PS50, Elayne developed original syllabi, assignments, and lectures that balanced intellectual rigor with accessibility, making complex material approachable without oversimplifying it.

One of Elayne's greatest strengths is her ability to foster inclusive and intellectually open classroom environments, particularly around politically sensitive topics. She is explicit with students that assigned readings will present competing viewpoints and that disagreement is expected when grounded in evidence. This approach allows students to engage deeply with contentious material while feeling respected and supported. Student evaluations from both courses consistently highlight Elayne's commitment to independent thinking, her refusal to impose her own views, and her success in creating a classroom culture where respectful disagreement is encouraged. These are essential skills – combining informed debate with respect for others – that both UCLA and our department are committed to fostering.

Elayne is also highly responsive to student learning needs. She regularly monitors student understanding and adapts her teaching accordingly, whether by revising pacing, clarifying expectations, or providing additional instructional support. Her courses include appropriate major assessments, transparent grading criteria, and opportunities for students

to practice skills before being evaluated. These practices reflect a strong command of evidence-based teaching strategies and a genuine commitment to student success.

Beyond formal instruction, Elayne takes mentorship seriously. She is approachable, attentive to student concerns, and generous with her time. She has supported students through office hours, letters of recommendation, and guidance on academic and professional pathways.

In sum, Elayne Stecher is an outstanding instructor whose teaching reflects rigor, inclusivity, and reflective practice. Her contributions as a Teaching Fellow and instructor have had a clear and positive impact on student learning. I recommend her for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award with the highest enthusiasm.

Sincerely,



Michael Ross
Professor

In the current academic environment, my goal has never been to convince students to memorize content or defer to my opinions. Instead, my teaching focuses on developing students' analytical skills: evaluating evidence, articulating and defending arguments, engaging productively with disagreement, and tolerating uncertainty. Across Political Science, International and Area Studies, Global Studies, and Global Health, I design discussion sections and lectures that are intellectually rigorous and inclusive and draw on evidence-based teaching practices.

I have served as a Teaching Assistant for upper-division, interdisciplinary courses including PS129 (War and Diplomacy), PS179 (Randomized Trials for Social Change), PS156A (Government and Politics of Russia), GLBLST102 (Globalization: Markets and Resources), and GH100 (Global Health and Development), as well as the graduate methods course PS200B (Linear Regression). I also developed and taught my two novel summer courses: PS169 (The Politics of Violent Conflict, Summer 2024) and PS50 (Introduction to Comparative Politics, Summer 2025 and Summer 2026). Teaching across departments and course levels has reinforced my focus on transferable analytical skills rather than fixed disciplinary conclusions.

Student evaluations consistently rate my teaching highly. In Fall 2025, my overall TA rating averages ranged from 8.26 to 8.86 out of 9 across three sections. For the two summer courses I taught, my overall instructor averages were 8.55/9 (Summer 2025) and 9/9 (Summer 2024).

A central focus of my teaching is identifying and addressing barriers to student learning. One recurring challenge students report is feeling overwhelmed by course materials in topically broad courses like GLBLST102. To address this, I redesigned sections to emphasize structured review and retrieval practices. I broke complex material into manageable components using guided key-term review, structured discussion, and tying concepts to concrete case studies. Rather than re-summarizing lecture content, sections helped students practice reasoning through examples. Students consistently described sections as "more digestible" than lecture, and noted that they "always understood the material after sections."[1]

Students are often reluctant to speak or disagree in discussion, especially when course material is sensitive, as in PS169. In these cases, I treat participation as a matter of instructional design. I implemented structured small-group discussions prior to whole-class conversations; we determined shared norms for respectful disagreement during the first week of class; and I designed assignments that progressively built students toward articulating and defending analytical positions. Students authored a policy-memo-style primer on a conflict of their choosing, evaluated competing theoretical explanations in a midterm paper, and advanced policy recommendations in a final presentation. Regarding course media, I emphasized that "assignment is not endorsement": we studied competing viewpoints, so disagreement was expected rather than penalized when grounded in evidence. Two PS169 students respectively

[1] Quotes from student reviews from Fall 2025 and Winter 2025 respectively.

wrote in their reviews, “[Elayne] tries really hard to not push her perspective/opinions on you… She encourages you to form your own opinions” and, “I liked that [Elayne] emphasized that we could disagree respectfully with our classmates’ opinions and with her own.”

I apply similar principles in quantitative and methods-oriented courses, including PS179 and PS200B, where anxiety can present a barrier to learning. In these settings, I normalize confusion, provide multiple explanations of key concepts, and walk through code and analysis in R step-by-step. Rather than providing solutions outright, I helped students learn how to approach unfamiliar problems and debug their own reasoning. One student wrote they entered PS179 feeling “very intimidated” but left confident because “being confused was never treated as a bad thing” in our section.

To support students in translating analytical skills into performance, I build scaffolding around major assessments. I develop study guides, host optional review sessions prior to exams, teach analytical writing techniques (e.g., PEEL approach, how to acknowledge alternative explanations), and provide prompt, constructive feedback. I also share examples of full-credit responses to reinforce transparency and expectations.

I engage in continuous pedagogical reflection beyond required training. Each quarter, I leave open an anonymous feedback form and revise discussion plans based on student input. I seek mentorship from experienced instructors in my department, including Frank Wyer (former instructor of the 495A–B sequence), and engage with UCLA Teaching and Learning Center resources, including Timely Resources, published guides, and workshops. I also share materials and approaches with other TAs.

My teaching extends beyond the classroom through mentorship. I have written letters of recommendation for internships, law school, and graduate programs, and I supervised two undergraduate research assistants over 18 months while conducting a multidisciplinary systematic review.

I view teaching as an ethical responsibility. In a context shaped by rapid information cycles and increasing reliance on AI, students are often encouraged to react quickly rather than reason carefully. My role is to counterbalance these pressures by helping students slow down, evaluate evidence, and justify their conclusions as empowered and responsible thinkers.

I understand teaching as an ethical and civic practice: one that shapes how students learn to reason, not only in classrooms, but in the world they inhabit after graduation. In an academic and social environment shaped by shortened attention spans, rapid information cycles, algorithmic amplification, and increasing reliance on artificial intelligence, students are often rewarded for speed, certainty, and reproduction rather than careful reasoning. I view teaching as an intervention in this environment. My goal is to equip students with the skills to evaluate evidence, construct and defend arguments, engage productively with disagreement, and tolerate ambiguity when answers are incomplete or contested.

This commitment is shaped in part by my own educational experience. Early in my academic life, I was highly deferential to authority and hesitant to disagree with instructors, even when I had questions or alternative interpretations. Over time, I came to see how this deference limited my learning. That experience informs my commitment to designing classrooms where disagreement is explicitly invited, structured, and treated as a core analytical skill rather than a social risk. I want students to leave my courses confident in their ability to question arguments, including those presented by authority figures, and to justify their positions using evidence.

In my teaching across Political Science, Global Studies, International and Area Studies, Global Health, and quantitative methods courses, I prioritize analytical skill development over content memorization. While substantive knowledge matters, I treat it as a vehicle for practicing reasoning rather than an endpoint. I want students to learn how to ask good questions, identify assumptions, distinguish empirical claims from normative judgments, and defend conclusions with appropriate evidence. This orientation shapes both my course design and my day-to-day teaching decisions.

A core principle of my teaching philosophy is that student participation is not a problem to manage, but a skill to cultivate. Many students arrive in the classroom reluctant to speak, especially when material is politically or ethically sensitive, or they're unsure whether disagreement is permitted. I explicitly challenge this dynamic by telling students that "assignment is not endorsement." Class media are intentionally selected to present competing viewpoints, including flawed or contested theories, precisely so they can be evaluated. Disagreement with authors, peers, or the instructor is expected when it is grounded in course readings, data, or case evidence.

To support this goal, I design learning environments that lower the social and cognitive costs of participation. I rely on structured discussion formats, such as small-group work that feeds into larger conversations, collaboratively developed "rules of engagement" to guide disagreements in the classroom, and prompts that require students to study and articulate multiple perspectives before taking a position. When students feel intellectually safe, they are more willing to test ideas, revise their thinking, and engage seriously with complexity. Frequently, I endeavor to

speak no more than half the time during my classes, to leave space for students to engage meaningfully with class materials and each other.

Accessibility and transparency are also central to my teaching philosophy. Students enter my classrooms with widely varying levels of preparation, confidence, and skills (particularly in statistics and programming). Rather than assuming uniform readiness, I treat confusion as a normal and expected part of learning. I explain concepts in multiple ways, model different approaches on how to work through uncertainty, and make expectations explicit through study guides, review sessions, grading criteria, and examples of strong work. I view feedback to students as a key component of instruction: it should be timely, specific, and oriented toward improvement. While my "harsh" grading has often been a surprise to students early on in the quarter, my teaching evaluations reveal students are more than capable of rising to the challenge – and that doing so builds their confidence in their own capabilities.

This philosophy is especially important in quantitative and methods-oriented courses, where anxiety can become a significant barrier to learning. My interdisciplinary training in political science and statistics shapes how I teach across qualitative and quantitative contexts. I am attentive to the different epistemologies and anxieties students bring to theory, data, and methods, and I design instruction that helps students translate skills across these domains rather than treating them as separate. In methods courses, I emphasize process over answers: how to approach unfamiliar problems, break them into steps, test alternative approaches, and debug reasoning. Normalizing confusion and slowing down analytical processes helps students build confidence through competence.

I also believe that effective teaching extends beyond course content. Some of the most impactful teachers in my own education supported me in navigating the hidden curriculum of higher education: how to apply for opportunities, seek mentorship, and manage challenges outside the classroom. These experiences shaped my view of instructors as key adult allies in students' lives. As a result, I see mentoring, accessibility, and out-of-class support as integral to my role as an educator. Writing letters of recommendation, advising students on academic and professional pathways, and supporting undergraduate research are extensions of my teaching philosophy.

Teaching, for me, is an iterative and reflective practice. I actively solicit student feedback during the term and adjust my teaching in response. I also seek mentorship from more experienced instructors and engage with pedagogical resources through the UCLA Teaching and Learning Center. This reflects my belief that good teaching is not static expertise, but ongoing learning.

Ultimately, I view teaching as an ethical responsibility. In a context that often encourages quick reactions and surface-level engagement, I aim to help students slow down, reason carefully, and justify their conclusions. By designing inclusive, evidence-based learning environments that prioritize critical inquiry over certainty, I seek to prepare students not only for academic success,

but for participation in civic, professional, and personal contexts as empowered, thoughtful, and independent thinkers.

GLBLST102 (F25)

1. "I think she is clearly knowledgeable and brings a good energy to get students involved. I also like that she has us consider everything from multiple perspectives rather than immediately accept something as fact."
2. "My T.A. was great at anticipating the obstacles or concerns we might have as students, about the course material but also with Perusall, projects, or academic requirements."

PS50 (Summer 2025)

1. "Ms. Stecher was committed to student success. She frequently checked in with us to see how our understanding of course materials was developing and sometimes adapted her teaching based on student feedback."
2. "Stecher is one of the best instructors I've had at UCLA. She communicates clearly, gives engaging presentations, has a good sense of humor, and she is very kind and respectful towards her students. Zero complaints."

GLBLST102 (W25)

1. "I really loved learning with Elayne. Her humor and down–to–earth personality really helped me feel comfortable in this class, especially because the content was a little daunting to me throughout…I also appreciated how she gauged our interest about certain activities she had planned for section and how she was willing to change the class plan to accommodate our preferences."
2. "I feel like the TA knows a lot about all topics discussed and she explains everything in a way so that everyone understands."
3. "Elayne is an amazing TA who put in so much extra effort to make the course material digestible. Not only is she knowledgeable, but she cares about how her students feel about the material and their mastery."

IASTD1 (F24)

1. "Overall, I found great value in these discussion sections and believe that it was a large aspect of success I had in the class. The TA was amazing at explaining the material, showing students different methods of looking at and understanding the material, integrated questions and key points thoroughly, and allowed me to understand the readings and examples more in depth. Assignments for participation were also greatly relevant to what was directly learned, and allowed me to prepare for exams and think about the material learned. TA also provided excellent review sections, notes, and discussion boards which allowed me to learn from my peers and have good discussions with them."

PS169 (Summer 2024)

1. "Professor Stecher is an extraordinarily engaging lecturer. She manages to make class fun and makes me actually want to do the readings. I typically never do the readings and still get A's, but in this class I actually read just so I could discuss with her. She also tries really hard to not push her perspective/opinions on you… She encourages you to form your own opinions. Also, this class was not that easy but I still liked it. Usually I hate hard classes but this was a rare instance where I enjoyed a somewhat difficult course. I think what made the difficulty rewarding was that we got to have class discussion so often and she was always very personable."
2. "She made sure that we facilitated productive and nuanced conversations in our breakout rooms. She kept class discussions going at a good pace…She seemed to genuinely care about our ability to understand the content and valued our insight. I also appreciated that she allowed the class to

disagree with each other. We discussed complex topics with often no right answer, so I liked that she emphasized that we could disagree respectfully with our classmates opinions and with her own."

PS156A (F22)

1. "Elayne was genuinely the best TA I have ever had…I happened to really enjoy attending section all quarter long because she fostered critical thinking skills and familiarized her students with strategies to help make the content more digestible…[O]ne of Elayne's strengths is how well she fostered a collaborative learning environment. She encouraged us to work with our peers and diversify our knowledge of the material we were learning, all while allowing us to do so in an inclusive and even fun setting."
2. "Elayne is simply an incredible TA... The structure of her discussion sections consisted of a combination of small group work and large group discussions. I felt this perfectly allowed everyone to feel comfortable speaking out to the whole class, and I felt like my understanding of the readings always expanded with discussion with my peers. Outside of this, she was always understanding of our workload and tried to help us as much as possible by giving us reading and studying techniques."

PS179 (S22)

1. "She was very good at explaining code and breaking it down and made it very understandable. Walking into this class, I was very intimidated, as I had never coded in my life before. R studio was entirely new to me, and I was very nervous to take this class. After the first discussion, I was a lot more confident because she explained everything so well and was very patient when we did not understand something. She was willing to explain code until it was clear and if we did not understand, we always knew she was available for office hours. Elayne was very approachable and I felt very comfortable asking her for help because even when I was really confused, she never made it seem that being confused was a bad thing."
2. "Stecher was an incredible guide in helping my classmates and I formulate our experiment proposal! She provided useful feedback while supporting our collective creation. I would say that would be one of her greatest strengths, because in a class of 20 students I wouldn't have expected collaborative work to run that smoothly. Another strength of hers that I must include is her patience and ability to explain things in multiple ways when my classmates or I didn't fully understand something the first time."

PS129 (F21)

1. "Elayne is awesome. She is so knowledgeable, but very approachable and explains things in an extremely digestible manner. She has improved my course understanding so much. I really value how she constantly challenges us to improve our thinking, but never in a harsh or discouraging manner. She is definitely one of, if not the best, TA I have ever had."
2. "I really liked the way that Elayne explained things. She managed to make the readings very easy to understand and was very accessible as a TA. I went to one of her office hours once and I left feeling like I understood everything a lot better. She was also a fair grader and really took the time to put meaningful comments on each of her student's midterms. Her optional review sessions also helped me do well in the class."

PS50: Introduction to Comparative Politics

Summer 2025

Last Revised: August 5, 2025

Instructor:
Elayne Stecher
elaynestecher@ucla.edu
Office hours: Monday / 1:30 - 2:30pm
and by appointment
To book OH: elaynestecher.com/oh/

Course Information:
Summer Session C (Aug. 4 - Sept 12)
Class meetings (online, synchronous)
Monday / 10:45am-12:50pm
Wednesday / 10:45am-12:50pm
Class Zoom link:

Course Description:

This undergraduate course introduces students to a subset of foundational concepts and analytical tools in comparative politics. We will examine major theoretical approaches to understanding political systems and explore core questions such as: Why are some countries democratic and some autocratic? How does globalization affect individuals' and countries' development?

Comparative politics encompasses a wide array of topics, far more than can be fully explored in a single course. This course offers a broad survey of some of the field's central questions, providing students with a foundation for thinking critically about global political phenomena. It also introduces the analytical frameworks and methods that political scientists use to develop arguments and evaluate evidence.

Drawing on cross-disciplinary insights, the course uses real-world studies from across the globe to ground abstract theories in concrete examples. In addition to gaining substantive knowledge of world politics, students will learn to apply the scientific method, critically evaluate political information, and craft well-supported comparative analysis.

Learning Objectives:

1. ***Students should develop familiarity with foundational concepts.*** You will be able to identify and define many key terms and ideas from this subfield of political science.
2. ***Students should think critically about and evaluate the theories they read.*** Assignment is not endorsement: we may read theories that are disprovable or flawed – that's the point! You are allowed (and encouraged) to disagree with theories (in whole or in part) as long as your argument is grounded in facts.
3. ***Students should develop comfort in comparative analysis.*** Comparative analysis allows us to identify patterns, explain political phenomena, and test theories by

examining similarities and differences across cases. Students will practice this key skill throughout the course and become familiar with useful tools, such as reading a regression table.

4. ***Students should be able to evaluate sources.*** Another key goal of this course is to teach students how to evaluate sources.

Expectations:

More than ever, students face unique learning challenges in a variety of contexts. You can expect flexibility, but you must remain engaged and communicative. My expectations of you include the following:

- You need to complete course readings as scheduled according to the syllabus
- You need to actively participate in discussions or contact me to discuss alternative assignments for participation credit
- You are free to disagree with me and with your peers, and you are free to voice this disagreement. However, you must be respectful and your questions and arguments should ultimately pertain to course content

Evaluation:

1. *Participation and Attendance (10%):* Classes will be held online, synchronously. This class will combine both lecture and discussion, often in breakout rooms. This format places a greater emphasis on student participation. Students are expected to complete all of the assigned readings prior to class each day and come prepared to participate in class discussions. You may make up attendance credit by submitting a 1-2 page reading memo (in your own words) for the class you miss. If you miss more than 3 classes, the maximum participation and attendance grade you can receive is a 90%.

2. *Discussion Leader (10%)*: Each student will be assigned one class for which they will serve as a discussion leader. Discussion leaders will be responsible for reading all of the required material for that class and developing 3-5 discussion questions that they will submit on BruinLearn by 11:59 pm PT the night before the class.

3. *Short Quizzes (20%)*: Students will be assigned 3-4 quizzes that emphasize key skills or ideas from each week of readings and lectures. These quizzes will directly prepare you for the midterm exam and can be completed as many times as necessary (so you should have no problem getting 100% by the end!). The quizzes will be due on Friday of Weeks 1-4 at 11:59 pm PT.

4. *Midterm Exam (40%):* Students will be given an exam that asks them to define key terms, practice key skills and conduct a short comparative analysis. This exam will be open note and due at the end of Week 5.

5. *Paper Presentation (20%):* Students will work in small groups to explain and teach an important paper in comparative politics from a pre-defined list. Students will record a ~15 minute video of their presentations and submit them by the end of Week 6.

More assignment details will be shared with students during class time.

Main Assignment Calendar:

Monday, August 4: Discussion Leaders are assigned; questions are due the day before class
Friday, August 8: Quiz 1 due @ 11:59 pm PT
Friday, August 15: Quiz 2 due @ 11:59 pm PT
Friday, August 22: Quiz 3 due @ 11:59 pm PT
Friday, August 29: Quiz 4 due @ 11:59 pm PT
Friday, Sept. 5: Take-home midterm exam due @ 11:59 pm PT
Friday, Sept. 12: Paper Presentation videos due @ 11:59 pm PT

Mid-Quarter Survey for Global Studies 102

How are we doing?

1. The TA has created an inclusive class environment.

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	
Stro	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Strongly Agree

2. I feel that my TA is organized and prepared to teach.

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	
Stro	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Strongly Agree

3. Section is engaging.

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	
Stro	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Strongly Agree

4. My TA is able to explain material clearly enough so that I am able to better understand class material.

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	
Stro	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Strongly Agree

5. Please indicate whether the following are useful or not useful to your learning

Mark only one oval per row.

	Very useful	Somewhat useful	Neutral	Somewhat not useful	Not useful
Big class discussion of key terms	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Small group discussion of readings	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Big group discussion of readings	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Kahoot game	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Opening up discussion for student-led questions	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

6. What is going well in section?

7. What could be improved? Do you have any specific suggestions on how to improve?

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Asking About Violence

Systematic Review of Past Evidence

Review conducted by Elayne Stecher with Research Assistants Ragini Srinivasan and Safa Saleem

What's the problem?

What are the effects of asking research participants to report on violence they've been exposed to in their lives? The short answer: we don't know. This is problematic for many reasons, but one of the most important is that the current research ecosystem (e.g., Institutional Review Boards, researchers, publishers, implementation partners) is only guided by a limited set of evidence to inform ethical decision-making in the research process, and that evidence may not be rigorous or relevant in many of the contexts that scholars of conflict wish to do research. Although researchers such as Jaffe et al. (2015) have collated and summarized existing evidence – ultimately finding that it is not overly harmful to ask research participants about their experiences with violence) – we assert that we need a more rigorous evidence base to guide ethical decision making around violence research.

What we know & what we don't

We conducted a systematic review of the literature expanding on Jaffe et al. (2015).[1] Our review covers the period of January 1967 - October 2014. The Jaffe et al. (2015) review concludes that, overall, while participating in trauma-related research may evoke distress in some participants, distress is not extreme and may be offset by benefits of participation. Our review covers January 2014 - December 2021.[2] Preliminary results of this review suggest that participating in research on violence does not have systematic negative impacts on participants – and may in fact provide net benefits to participants. We also find that, in studies which measure the longer-term effects of research participation, self-reported regret or harms do not tend to persist. It is worth noting here that the concept of harms and benefits is not well-defined in the literature: while some researchers conflate negative affect (such as reporting feeling "more emotional than expected" due to research participation) with psychological measures (like self-reported anxiety) or self-reported participation regret, others disaggregate these categories of responses from one another. Similarly, the conception and measurement of benefits varied across papers, although there do seem to be relatively straightforward categories of benefits (individual benefits and altruistic- or global benefits) that appear in measures. Finally, while many survey modules include questions about consent, it is unclear how – if at all – informed consent (or the lack of it) factors into calculations of the net-effects of research.

We found 39 new studies. The vast majority occurred in the United States (see Figure 1). The studies frequently utilized convenience samples: of the 39 papers in our review, over a third (n = 14) used undergraduate students as their primary sample (see Figure 2). The vast majority of this research occurred in non-conflict contexts. About half (n = 20) examined the impact of asking about gender-based violence, including intimate partner violence and adult sexual abuse, in non-conflict contexts. Only three studies primarily looked at conflict-related violent experiences: one study of

[1] Jaffe, Anna E., David DiLillo, Lesa Hoffman, Michelle Haikalis and Rita E. Dykstra. 2015. "Does it hurt to ask? A meta-analysis of participant reactions to trauma research." Clinical Psychology Review 40:40–56.

[2] Our search was conducted using consistent search term combinations on Google Scholar and Web of Science.

veterans in the United States suffering from PTSD, one study of adult Somalis living in refugee camps in Ethiopia, and one study of adult civil war survivors in Sri Lanka (See Figure 3). Women are overrepresented across the samples: in the 37 studies where the gender breakdown of participants was provided, women comprised the entire sample in 13 and at least 60% of the sample in 27 studies (See Figure 4). Fourteen of the 39 studies included a longer-term follow up after the initial participation (ranging from 1 week to 3 years later).

Only four of the 39 studies experimentally evaluated the impact of asking participants about their experience of violence, and all four were conducted on college students in the United States. Researchers found either null effects or small magnitudes of distress in the immediate aftermath of asking about violence. These effects did not persist in the three experimental studies which included follow-up measures (2 weeks - 1 month after initial treatment).

Taken together with the Jaffe et. al (2015) evidence, the review highlights limitations in the existing evidence that limit generalizability to violent contexts:

1) the vast majority of the evidence is non-experimental, and so the credibility of our causal inferences about the effects of research participation is uncertain;

2) study populations from the U.S. and other WEIRD[3] contexts are overrepresented;

3) study populations across most studies may not generalize to broader populations;

4) less than half measure long-term effects of participation, raising the question of whether estimated effects persist; and

5) the subset of studies that examine the impact of asking participants about interpersonal violence tend to focus specifically on intimate partner violence and not other types of violence exposure.

In short, biases in the current literature with respect to gender, location, violence type, and measurements of reactions to research limit our understanding of the harms and benefits of asking respondents to reflect on the violence they have experienced in their lives. We thus conclude that more evidence is needed based on credible research designs for estimating causal effects from a wide set of populations and contexts.

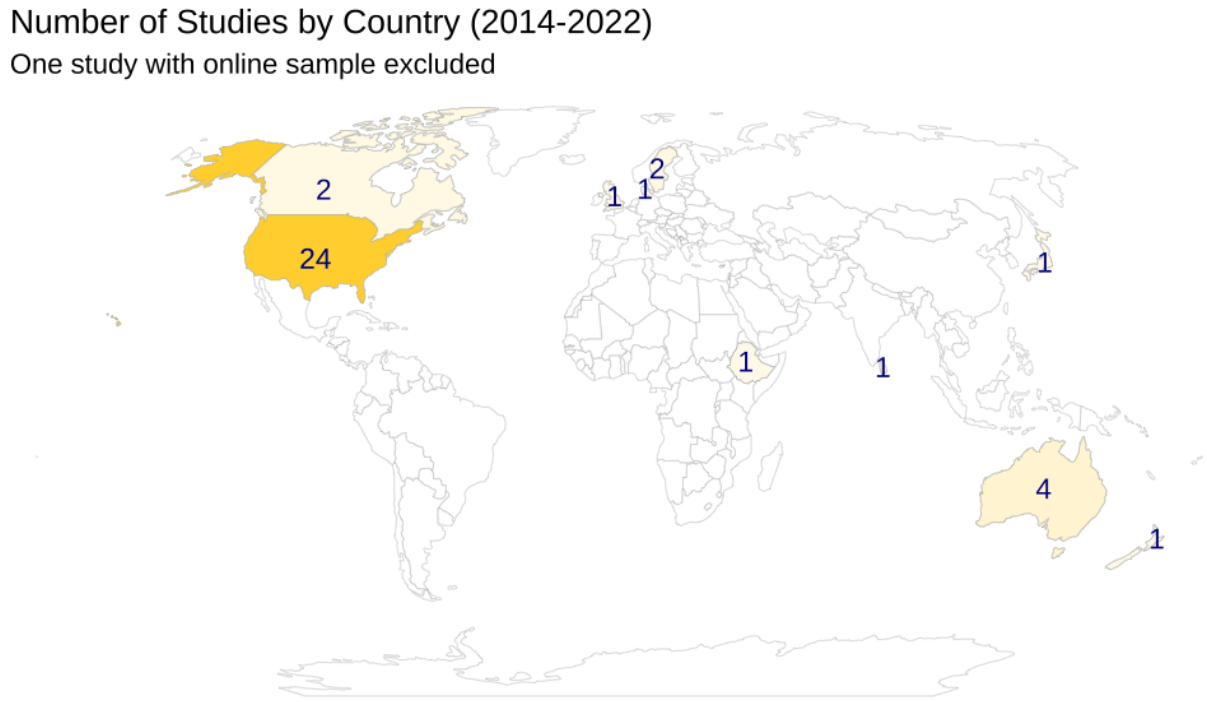
Details of our systematic review

In keeping with the criteria established in Jaffe et al. (2015), we included studies in our review in which the majority of participants were adults (aged 18+) who were asked about the impact (positive or negative) of participating in violence research and who were reflecting on their own personal experiences of exposure to violence (e.g., not a parent responding on behalf of their child). We only studies in which the intervention was *not* designed to elicit emotional reactions from participants, which would obfuscate the measurement of the effects of participating in the research.[4] We expanded the focus of Jaffe et al. (2015) to include more types of violent victimization: we included search terms "terrorism" and "crime", and retained studies about medical trauma (e.g., non-suicidal self injury) and bereavement.

[3] "WEIRD" = Western, educated, industrialized, rich, and democratic, samples often used in psychology research.
[4] When we found a relevant study where the treatment arm might influence respondent reactions to research but the control would not, we retained just the results from the control group.

Figures

Figure 1: Map of Study Locations (2014 - 2022)



Stats for map:

Country	**Total Number of Studies**
United States	24
Sweden	2
Sri Lanka	1
Japan	1
Canada	2
Australia	4
United Kingdom	1
Denmark	1

New Zealand	1
Ethiopia	1
Global (Amazon MTurk)	

Figure 2: Study Populations (Students)

Primary Population of Focus	**Total Number of Studies**
College/University Students	14
Non-Students	25

Figure 3: Type of Violence Experienced (Non-Independent Categories)

Primary Violent Experience Studied	**Total Number of Studies**
Sexual Abuse (Adult), IPV, GBV	20
CSA, CPA, Adverse Childhood Experiences	6
Natural Disaster	3
Medical / Psychiatric Trauma	14
Combat-Related (Veterans)	1

Conflict-Related (Civilians), incl. Refugees	2
Financial Trauma	1

Figure 4: Gender Breakdown of Participants

Gender of Participants	**Total Number of Studies**
All women (100% women)	13
Mostly women (60-99% women)	14
Roughly equal (41-59% women)	4
Mostly men (1-40% women)	5
All men (0% women)	1
Unknown	2

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Elizabeth Victoria Shlimovich

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I took Ms. Stecher's Politics of Violent Conflict (PS169) course in the summer of 2024. I had initially enrolled in the course because of my interest in the subject matter of political science (my major). I had developed a particular curiosity about international relations (my concentration).

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Ms. Stecher beams with passion for the subjects she teaches. Not only is she brilliant, but her unique compassion for human struggle translates into an incredible ability to inspire her students. I consistently left class with my worldview challenged, plenty of questions, and newly-piqued curiosities. She encouraged me to change my conflict from my original choice. Initially challenging, this nudge out of my comfort zone morphed into an unexpected area for growth as I delved head-first into a topic completely foreign to me (as opposed to one I knew well).
When Ms. Stecher's students engaged with the class material or provided insight into new conflict research discoveries, she asked questions to encourage digging deeper, drawing connections and providing fresh perspectives fueling intellectual curiosity and critical thinking. Frequent small and group discussions encouraged active engagement with our own research and the class readings as well as with our peers, creating an environment for collaborative brainstorming and analyzing issues through a plethora of lenses.
At the end of the quarter, Ms. Stecher received an overwhelming amount of gratitude for her contagious energy and effective teaching style that left a permanent mark on the psyche of the future change-makers who graduated her class.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Though difficult with the rapidly-moving quarter system, Ms. Stecher's class encouraged the exploration of an ongoing conflict in depth through quarter-long research and a detailed research paper, where we compiled factual knowledge and proposed innovative potential solutions, culminating in an even more elaborate final presentation. I so appreciated the ability to engage in such a hands-on way, immersing myself in the Syrian Civil War from the second week of the quarter until the last day. Since the course's end, I have expanded my knowledge of the conflict through nuanced conversations with Syrian friends (made possible by the geopolitical understanding I acquired while in PS169).

Ms. Stecher's approach to diversity of thought is unparalleled to anything I'd experienced as a UCLA student. She welcomed difference of opinion, asked intriguing questions, and invited creative, outside-the-box resolutions to global conflicts stuck in deadlock for decades, often fueled by underlying, seemingly unresolvable identity-based tensions. Having learned the basics of our respective conflicts, she urged us to examine the endless political turmoil, violence, and economic despair and, informed by our own unique backgrounds and perspectives, to come up with unprecedented ways to end these dire situations and finally begin the healing and rebuilding process.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Ms. Stecher cares deeply for the success of all her students. Her academic brilliance paired with her warm energy make it a joy and a privilege to be taught by her. Her class was my favorite and most meaningful at UCLA.

She is kind, approachable, and open-minded. She is not only responsive to feedback, but welcomes it.

If I had the opportunity to take more classes with her, I would have leaped at the chance.

In my humble opinion, despite the outstanding level of excellence I have witnessed from UCLA's faculty, there is no one more deserving of this award.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I began working under Elayne before my sophomore year, but even then, she consistently emphasized that she valued and respected my opinions. She held weekly meetings with me and another research assistant, where she encouraged us to think slowly and deeply – a skill that is increasingly rare today.

Our research required analyzing thousands of political science and sociology papers and making difficult decisions about whether or not they should be included in our meta-analysis. At times, after extensive deliberation, we held conflicting views. Elayne always emphasized forming our own independent judgments and engaging in open, thoughtful conversation, rather than deferring to authority.

Additionally, it is rare for educators to find the right balance between challenging students and understanding their limits and capabilities. However, Elayne did this exceptionally well. In every meeting, she asked us which tasks felt too easy, manageable, or overly challenging, and she adjusted future assignments accordingly. She never assumed that she knew what we could do; instead, she continuously tailored her pedagogy to our individual strengths and growth areas. This level of intentional, student-centered teaching is a special philosophy I have not seen in any other mentor to this day.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

From the beginning, Elayne never made us feel inadequate for being confused. On the contrary, she actively encouraged confusion. In every meeting, she pushed us to approach problems from new perspectives and to sit with complex questions that have no easy answers.

Elayne was also deeply supportive of our academic and professional development. Whenever we met, she regularly asked what skills we wanted to build and what we hoped to gain from the research assistantship. Much of our work involved qualitative analysis of papers, but when I expressed interest in strengthening my quantitative skills in R, Elayne immediately adapted my responsibilities to support that goal.

Alongside this, she ensured that we were treated not merely as "assistants" but as fellow researchers. Specifically, she integrated me and the other undergraduate assistant into meetings with the broader research team, invited us to present our meta-analysis, and coached us throughout the process. She showed that learning comes not only from completing assigned tasks but from asking meaningful questions, thinking creatively, and engaging in intellectual dialogue.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant Letter of Recommendation
In support of Elayne Stecher
Submitted by: Lula Panos
Due: February 6, 2026 (5:00 PM)

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)
I took Elayne Stecher's Comparative Politics class as a summer course at UCLA.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)
Ms. Stecher consistently pushed me to think critically through the way she structured the course and guided students through difficult material. She chose readings that complemented each other by adding nuance to the main question we were wrestling with. For example, what conditions actually produce strong states? We compared Tilly's argument that states are forged through war preparation with Olson's theory that states emerge through rational self-interest and the organized capacity for violence. Her weekly assignments asked us to generate our own questions about the readings. This was both fun and challenging because it pushed me to identify the core themes of each paper and form my own interpretations of the arguments. By forming my own opinions, I also became genuinely curious about how my peers understood and responded to the readings. This made me more engaged in group discussions because I could prod areas of the text I was genuinely curious about.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)
Ms. Stecher consistently made complex material accessible and meaningful. She introduced difficult readings by beginning the class with a "defining terms" section. I really appreciated this because it invited me to ask questions without the task seeming too open-ended or unfocused. Outside of class, I attended Ms. Stecher's office hours multiple times to discuss course readings and to seek guidance while writing my final essay. A specific time Ms. Stecher helped me was understanding an empirical correlational study: The Colonial Origins of Comparative Development: An Empirical Investigation. She helped me interpret what the data actually showed, including how variables were used to measure long-term institutional development. She walked me through it with both patience and compassion. She also revisited how to do this in class to ensure that all students felt strong in their abilities to analyze the data confidently. For my final essay, she also suggested I incorporate the "Salah Effect" case study on Mohamed Salah's influence in reducing anti-Muslim prejudice among Liverpool fans, which significantly strengthened my essay.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding

candidate for this award. (100 words max)

One of the most impactful moments for me was the conversation we had about this case study during her office hours. She spoke about how the patterns observed demonstrated that when people are united by pride and shared purpose, it can override prejudice and create a space for respect. We discussed how these insights could be applied across different countries in other political situations to build understanding even between historically divided groups. Ms. Stecher's ability to take a complex reading like that and anchor it in something meaningful and relevant is what made her such an impactful teacher for me.

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POLITICAL SCIENCE DEPARTMENT
4289 BUNCHE HALL
BOX 951472
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1472

EMAIL: mepeters@ucla.edu
PHONE: 718-757-0958
www.polisci.ucla.edu

February 6, 2026

Distinguished Teaching Award Committee

Dear Committee Members,

It is my great pleasure to nominate **Elayne Stecher** for a Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. I have had the privilege of working with Elayne twice as the teaching assistant for my course Global Studies 102, a core undergraduate class that introduces students to international political economy and comparative political analysis. Across both terms, Elayne distinguished herself as an exceptionally prepared, thoughtful, and student-centered instructor whose teaching had a profound impact on student learning and engagement.

Elayne consistently arrived at section meetings meticulously prepared and regularly developed new instructional materials to help students better understand complex readings and theoretical concepts. Rather than simply reviewing content, she tailored her sections to reinforce the most challenging material from lecture and readings, helping students identify key themes and apply them to exams and assignments. Students repeatedly noted how valuable this approach was, especially given the length and difficulty of the readings in the course. One student remarked that Elayne "tailored her sections towards the material from the past week covered in class—focusing on readings… helping to understand them fully," while another emphasized her ability to clarify "big concepts that would be covered on both the midterm and final."

What truly sets Elayne apart, however, is her deep commitment to her students' well-being and success. She fostered an inclusive and supportive learning environment in which students felt comfortable voicing confusion, asking questions, and participating in ways that suited their comfort level. Multiple students highlighted her empathy, noting that she was especially understanding of student mental health and energy levels—particularly important given that sections met late in the day and, at times, in an online format. One student wrote that Elayne had a "calming presence" and "helped me get through this class," while another described her as "one of the most accommodating, welcoming, and understanding professors I've had."

Elayne was also remarkably intentional about inclusivity and engagement. Early in the course, she surveyed students about their interests and worked to structure section discussions around

those topics. She encouraged participation without ever shaming students who preferred to contribute via Zoom chat rather than speaking aloud, helping even hesitant students feel safe and valued. As one student put it, “She encourages participation but doesn’t shame students who don’t feel comfortable speaking… Overall, I think anyone would be lucky to be in her class.”

Perhaps most telling is the consistency of student feedback across multiple terms. Students described Elayne as knowledgeable, passionate, kind, humorous, and deeply invested in teaching. One wrote simply, “Stecher is one of the best instructors I’ve had at UCLA. Zero complaints.” Another observed that “instructing is clearly something she cares deeply about,” and that she regularly adapted her teaching based on student feedback to ensure student success.

In sum, Elayne Stecher exemplifies the very best of undergraduate teaching at UCLA.

Sincerely,



Margaret Peters
Professor and Vice Chair of Graduate Studies
Political Science
UCLA